

COMP1779 Reflection

COMP1779 Programming for Games and Digital Media

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Introduction

The past twelfth weeks, I have been studying on the basics of how to program in JavaScript and understanding HTML features. I have been taught how to use important HTML tags such as '<canvas>' to create simple two-dimensional software and make them interactive using ID attributes and lines of JavaScript. On the final week, I used everything I had learnt to make an arcade style pong game, including an computer-controlled player and a few extra features I coded on my one.

This report will talk about what went well during the last twelfth weeks in my studies, and what could've been better. This will then be followed up with a conclusion talking about what I will do in future to make sure I learn from my mistakes. Things such as how well I've been organised, my management on time, or what techniques and skills I used will be discussed. By writing this report, I am understanding myself and what I do good or could be better on.

What Went Well

While my time management wasn't the best, each Monday I would always make sure to get as much done as soon as lectures were over. The main advantage this would give was to keep me ahead of deadlines, as well as possible opportunities to ask questions in lab sessions if I get stuck anywhere. I felt being at campus were my best advantages to get work done as computers there are designed to make software easier to use. For example, the King William floor one computers included second monitors which made it easier to organise my windows so I could have the lab instructions on one screen while doing my coding on Microsoft VS in the other.

The main thing that I can say went well during the last twelfth weeks is the knowledge I've already had since 2014, using the programming language C-Sharp to develop software on a game engine. While this is different to programming for a web browser with JavaScript, these two languages are known to be greatly similar which allowed me little research due to what I already know with C-Sharp. I've also been able to understand the differences visually between JavaScript and C-Sharp, the most notable being how variables/references are setup as well as how functions are typed. Understanding multiple coding languages is good as it helps my mind to be flexible, using what language is widely accepted for which software.

I also attempted to push beyond what was being taught in lectures, including my own features. In week twelfth, I decided to include more into the pong game than just a simple computer-controlled player, such as a 'Serve Speed' feature that would control how fast the ball would be moving while also being multiplied by the angle of where the ball hits the paddle. I felt by going further than what was being taught, it would prove that not only I understood each lecture, but also show how confident I felt.

When I first started this module, I didn't expect it to teach me much considering everything I already know with C-Sharp and HTML/CSS, but I was surprised I learnt so much during the last twelfth weeks in this module, whether it was about ternary operators or even knowing Java and JavaScript are different. The knowledge I've learnt from this module makes me feel confident for the next ones that will be coming in future years.

Could've Been Better

I could've done a lot better with time management during this module, there has been a few points during the past weeks where I've either fallen behind or left work for last minute until next Monday. This can prove dangerous if I don't improve on this as it could possibly get in the way of my grades when the difficulty rises in studies next year.

Alongside time management, I should take the time to do extra tasks more for each week. Doing so will show that I'm keen to learn what I can, and that knowledge could even help in later modules. While understanding that the extra tasks can increase my grades, as a university student I want to be able to do them not just for the grades, but because I'm willing to learn further.

During the past weeks, I've only asked for help during lab sessions once. While a lot of the time I can work out problems I come across independently, there has been times where I've been stuck on specific lines of code for almost an hour that leave stress on myself when trying to find a solution. I need to learn to ask help from my tutor when the time is right, as it could help in not only saving time but give me a chance to understand the logic of programming more.

While not needed, having an external hard drive could've help me to be organised for this module, and be useful for ones later. It would allow me to take my files wherever I go without the need for internet on any computer. The reason this isn't entirely needed however is because I've made good use of Microsoft's OneDrive services, which are built into the Windows Explorer software where I've been editing my files from each lab session.

I noticed when I'm coding whether in lab tasks or personal projects, I sometimes forget to comment on my coding. I need to get in the practice of commenting more, especially on parts that could be hard to understand to others reading my scripts. Commenting is very important and I'm going to need to do so as often as possible especially if I'm to collaborate in teams for later modules. I feel I could do better at being more descriptive when I write out comments, as I worry anyone else who're to read my code may not understand what I'm implying.

Conclusion

I wish that I managed my time a lot better, and to do so I feel I should take the time to stay in campus more to get work done sooner. There are many advantages that I will gain while studying in campus than if I were to finish off the rest at home, and the sooner the work is done the more time to focus on other things needed.

I should get over my fear of asking for help rather than trying to solve issues on my own, and to ask them as soon as I can before next week. Two minds can help to find the issue much faster, and it will give me a chance to understand what causes the error. It would help majorly to get to make friends in lab sessions not only for help in lab sessions, but for the next coming years studying in university.

As teachers have suggested, I should consider purchasing an external hard drive for storing my work on, and while I wouldn't need it entirely, it could prove useful in later modules where I'll be saving files with huge sizes.

For code commenting, I should try to work with others more whether in university or outside to get better practice on collaborating. This will help me on how I should word my comments for what others would understand best, and so I can see how important it is to get in this habit. If I practice this, it will greatly help in futures modules that involve collaborating with other students.